SEX ABUSE IN FILM INDUSTRY

THE ROT IN MOLLYWOOD

The release of the Hema Committee report findings has led to uproar in Kerala, with many women actors coming forward to report abuse

By **JEEMON JACOB**



A whole can of worms has opened up in the Malayalam film industry after the Pinarayi Vijayan-led Kerala government released the Hema Committee report on August 19, almost five years after it was submitted on December 31, 2019.

Set up four months after a popular actress was abducted and abused in a car in Kochi in February 2017, the three-member committee comprising Justice K. Hema, veteran actress Sarada and retired civil servant K.B. Valsalakumari was meant to examine the working conditions of women in the film industry. Constituted after friends of the victim formed a Women in Cinema Collective (WCC) and bore down on the government, the committee's report was destined to be a hot potato. The Pinarayi government kept it in cold storage on the pretext that its release would be an invasion of privacy of the victims as well as the perpetrators. In fact, Justice Hema herself is said to have written to the government, saying the report should not be made public as it contained sensitive information about sexual abuse.

A Kerala High Court order finally forced the government's hand, and it released a 233-page redacted version of the 299-page final report . Among the ugly revelations was how underage artistes were abused at auditions and shooting locations. The Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act states that anyone with knowledge of a sexual assault on a minor should file a police complaint, which makes the CM's office guilty of inaction.

Meanwhile, fresh stories of alleged abuse in Mollywood are surfacing every day. On August 23, Bengali actress Sreelekha Mitra alleged that celebrated film director and now ex-chairman of the government-run Kerala Chalachitra Academy Ranjith misbehaved with her in 2009 when she auditioned for his film *Paleri Manikyam: Oru Pathirakolapathakathinte Katha*. Kolkata-based Malayalam film director Joshy Joseph has also corroborated that Sreelekha had contacted him that night in a state of utter shock. "The production company didn't even pay her return fare," alleges Joshy. Ranjith denied the allegation and later resigned from the Academy post, but not before culture minister Saji Cherian got himself into a tangle, saying the director needn't resign over "mere allegations", adding that the ruling CPI(M) still backed him. The remark came back to bite, with even Left-leaning filmmakers such as Aashiq Abu and Bhadran saying that those found guilty should be punished. CPI(M) legislator and veteran actor Mukesh is among those in the accused list now.

The Left Front govt will find it hard to explain why it did not act on the report when the case comes up next for hearing on Sept. 10 in the HC

In all this, it's the Association of Malayalam Movie Artists (AMMA) that has come off worst. Their apathy even after the 2017 incident was palpable, but this time the Hema committee findings have led to a major upheaval. The entire 17-member executive committee of AMMA, including president and superstar Mohanlal and general secretary actor Siddique (police have filed an FIR against him for alleged rape of an aspiring actress) resigned on August 27. At least three members have been named in alleged abuse cases. AMMA has some 500 actors who are mem-